

It Hurts to be Pretty

written by

Laura Pereira

INT. BEDROOM - DAY

A bedroom. Clothes laid down on a bed, still tagged. MOTHER places the last skinny jeans and calls out

MOTHER
DAUGHTER!! Come in here, I have
some stuff for you

An 8 years old kid storm in, excited, wondering if it's a gift. When she stares at the bed, the excitement fades and turns into disappointment.

She arranges her face. Almost convincing.

DAUGHTER
Oh!! Thank you mom.

MOTHER
Go on! Try them on.

She takes off the pijama pants, still wearing an underpant on her skintone, and puts the first jeans.

FLASH CUT - Kettlepot in the stove and starting slowly to whistle, still very quietly.

A tag with sparkling glitter. Her older sister would adore it. She hates it.

FLASH CUT - jeans tag on skin. Scratching.

DAUGHTER
Mom, it's beautiful. But do you
think we can cut the tag?

MOTHER
Sure! Let me cut it for you.

She takes the scissor, already waiting in the drawer. She pulls the waistband out and SNAPS it on the left and SNAPS it on the right.

MOTHER (CONT'D)
There you go. How is it?

FLASH CUT - jeans tag on red skin. Red. Scratching.

DAUGHTER
Well... it isn't much better. It's
still itching.

MOTHER
Well, how? The tag is gone.

Worse than before. The bed still full.

DAUGHTER

Oh, ok. I don't know. It's ok. I'll
try the next one

She takes them off. The skin red as if an allergy.

FLASH CUT – jeans tag on red skin. Red. Scratching.

FLASH CUT – a shirt comes on.

FLASH CUT – her neck. Red. Scratching.

FLASH CUT – a shirt coming off.

FLASH CUT – a shirt comes on.

FLASH CUT – her neck. More red. Scratching.

FLASH CUT – Kettlepot in the stove, now with a loud deafening
whistle.

FLASH CUT – a jeans coming off.

FLASH CUT – a jeans comes on.

FLASH CUT – jeans tag on red skin. More red. Scratching.

FLASH CUT – a shirt coming off.

FLASH CUT – a shirt comes on.

FLASH CUT – her neck. Scratching. Skin breaking. Blood.

FLASH CUT – her lower back. Scratching. Skin breaking. Blood.

The MOTHER is clearly bothered, she went through all that
trouble and still nothing ever seems good enough.

MOTHER

Ok, this is the last one. What do
you think of this shirt?

DAUGHTER

It's ok.

She scratches her neck again.

MOTHER

If you don't like, I'll return. But
if you keep it, you better wear it

She glances at more than half already in the returning bin.

DAUGHTER
Ok! We can keep this one

MOTHER
Great! I'll return these

MOTHER takes the clothes and leaves.

Door closes. She frantically rips everything off. She breathes. Eyes closed. Relief. The pijama pants back on. She puts the new clothes in the closet. Pijama shirt back on.

FLASH CUT - pijama shirt tag on red skin

FLASH CUT - Kettlepot in the stove, back to a gentle whistle.

GRANDMA walks in, with the gorgeous straight hair just like her mother's and sister's. She comes with a smile, happy to see the kid.

DAUGHTER
GRANDMA!!!!

DAUGHTER runs to hug her. She hugs back. Then sees the hair.

GRANDMA
Why don't you brush that hair???

DAUGHTER
I did!!!!

GRANDMA
Well, I'll have to do it again.

Exhausted, she sits. GRANDMA returns with a brush and begins.

DAUGHTER
Ouch!!! Ouch!!! It hurtss.

FLASH CUT - Kettlepot in the stove, back to loud whistle.

GRANDMA
Well baby... it hurts to be pretty.
It's just how it is...

Hair pulling. Wavy and dry, tangling more with each stroke. Resisting the attempt to be made straight.

FLASH CUT - Salon chair, the kid with red watering eyes. Chemical straightening being added to each strand of hair. Scratching scalp. Itching eyes. Looks at the mirror. Cries.

CUT TO BLACK.

LOGLINE

It Hurts To Be Pretty is a story about any girl, but in this case, about an undiagnosed autistic queer kid, struggling to feel confident in the way the society expects girls to show and behave. Starting off with the sensory issues, in a community that wasn't prepared to deal with it. Going through body shame, and the need to wear uncomfortable clothings even when alone at home. It depicts the lives of many undiagnosed women that struggle to feel understood when they've been trained to mask and conform. To seek validation from men, or boys. It would go on to explore how our own "defaults" were often family induced. Not even issues before we allowed in the outside view. How plastic surgery can be so recklessly offered to kids, so they look more like the plastic and rigid white standard. It ends with the kid starring at the mirror and no longer recognizing or loving herself. Then as the mirror shatters, the kid runs off to a green field of dream-like escape. From the shattered mirror, the image of her older self appears and runs after her. As the kid runs non-stop still crying and fighting her own feelings, the adult struggles to reach her. The kid finally falls, exhausted and crying in her own hands. The older version then brew her a tea that she drinks as the kid's makeup is removed. Then the clothes exchanged for something comfortable. The hair watered and properly conditioned, forming beautiful curls that were always there. The kid cries, asking if she's really a witch, and why can't she be a princess. Then the older self, a self-acclaimed witch, no longer a scarred kid accused of being such, would explain that a witch is only the fairy godmother of those same tales. Just too powerfull not to be feared. Then handles her a beautiful handmade wand and the hug she so longed.